



Claiming a territory

Some animal territories are used only for mating, but they still need enough space and food for a growing family. This male tree frog has claimed one of the tiniest territories imaginable—a pool of rainwater in the leaves of a bromeliad plant. The male attracts a female with his mating call. The female then lays her eggs in the pool, high up in the rain forest canopy.



Fancy dress

With their fan-shaped crests and brilliant orange plumage, male Guianan cocks-of-the-rock put on a spectacular show. During the breeding season, they strut, jump, and squawk at their lek on the forest floor. They sometimes clash head-on, furiously flapping their wings. Females come to choose a male and mate. Then, they fly off to raise their family elsewhere.

Ritual combat

Many animals avoid violent fights by holding ritual combats to decide which male gets the upper hand. During these contests, the stronger male asserts his supremacy and the loser gets a chance to back down.



Rival male loses challenge by suffering a wound to the neck



Twisting adders

Rival male adders twist together as they crawl across the ground. They rear up and press against one another over and over again, until one of the snakes gives in.



Wrestling frogs

Poison dart frogs are highly territorial. Males fight off intruders by winning wrestling matches, where the frogs grapple with their front legs. Females also wrestle to win the best nesting sites.



Fly standoff

Male stalk-eyed flies have eyes at the end of extremely slender stalks. When two males meet, they stand face to face and size each other up. The fly with the longest eye stalks wins the contest.